

together. However, STA does not produce a single printout nor does it produce an elimination round bracket.

A second potential improvement deals with cumulation sheets. Currently, there is no option for displaying adjusted speaker point totals or speaker ranks. Most tournaments use the former for breaking team and speaker ties, and many tournaments still use ranks as an additional tie-breaker for individual speaker awards. While this information is available on the Rank Order of Teams display, it does not appear on the cumulation sheets. Including these two items would enhance the usefulness of the cumulation sheets considerably.

Finally, STA could better accommodate small tournaments. Because pairings are constrained by past meetings rather than potential meetings, the software has difficulty pairing small divisions, especially when multiple schools have multiple teams. Unless a tournament director is careful, small divisions might seem to be matching well through the early rounds of a tournament, but turn out to be locked in to violating normal matching constraints in the latter rounds. While it is certainly possible to use the manual pairing mode and a pre-set schematic to minimize this problem, STA could use a round-robin style matching option to ensure that all teams can have a maximum range of opponents.

While it is unlikely that any tournament software package can address every issue and satisfy the preferences of every tournament director, Smart Tournament Administrator remains a powerful tournament administration package. But perhaps the finest feature of STA is the programmer. Larson continues to adapt his software to the needs and preferences of the debate community. His selfless service to the debate community is at the heart of STA's success.

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Edwards, Rich. *Tab Room on the PC*. Version 04-04-2001. Freeware.

I should say from the outset that I consider Rich Edwards the closest thing that Baptists have to a Saint. He set the standard for tournament software pricing by offering his program for free when many gladly would have paid fistfuls for it. When I encountered a problem at 3:00 P.M. and Edwards suggested that I call him at 2:00 A.M. while he was on vacation, I

began to appreciate that he was something special. The contributions Edwards has made to tournament administration are amazing and, largely, un-rewarded. He has helped prove to the world that tournaments really can be run a lot faster on computers, and every time we leave a tournament before 1:00 A.M. we all owe Edwards a debt of gratitude. His tournament administration applications are used at any number of important tournaments, including the National Debate Tournament, and they are field-tested and battle ready.

Available Versions. Edwards' only religious failing is his strange devotion to MacIntosh products. The original version of his tournament software was written for the MacIntosh platform, and bore the name "Tab Room on the Mac" (TRM). Much like Augustine, Edwards has undergone an incomplete conversion process late in life, and has designed a PC version of the software called "Tab Room on the PC" (TRPC). The most recent version of the Mac application, TRM97, was last updated in July 1998, partially because the program is more thoroughly de-bugged than its PC counterpart, and partially due to decreased demand. Edwards has no current plans to resume updating TRM97, but he might be talked into it at some later date. I am unaware of any specific incompatibilities with more recent Mac operating systems, but I did witness firsthand one experience where TRM97 running on OS 9 experienced a system crash in which the hard drive was wiped clean. It is unclear whether loading TRM97 and the demise of the hard drive were directly related to each other, but the sequence of events was frightening.

Updates to TRPC, on the other hand, are frequent, with the most recent released in April 2001. I am aware of no incompatibilities with Windows 9x operating systems, but I have not tried to run the program on Windows ME. Edwards is committed to providing current updates to the TRPC for the foreseeable future.

TRPC is available free of charge, and can be downloaded via the Internet. The direct link URL is: http://www.baylor.edu/~Richard_Edwards/. The software can also be accessed by entering through the Baylor web domain (www.baylor.edu) and searching for faculty homepages, or simply by typing "Rich Edwards" in the Google search engine (www.google.com). In addition to TRPC, the website has download links for TRM97 and an individual events tournament administration application (TRIEPC) for the PC platform.

I have had the experience of trying to download TRPC in a computer lab with five computers and having it install successfully on only three. After considerable consultation with the lab technicians, we finally concluded that it was a problem with the security setup on the two unfriendly computers. The lesson I took from the experience was that, especially

if using lab computers, it is a good idea to download the program in advance to make sure that the setup of the computers does not prevent the installation of downloaded software. Otherwise, my experiences with operating TRPC on lab computers have been positive, including having no problems printing over a networked printer.

The Big Picture for Beginning Users. If you have not used one of the Tab Room applications before, three things are essential. First, make sure that you download and read the operating manual. Second, find someone who has used the program before and can answer questions. Most of the routines are intuitive if you know what's going on, but it is important that you have an experienced user around who can tell you where to look. Third, if you do not do either of the first two, hire extra security to keep the angry mob from burning down the tab room when 5:00 A.M. strikes and you have yet to release round two.

There are three phases of program operation to master. Each phase has a distinct set of options that you will use, and knowing the routines for one phase will not necessarily help you for another. The first phase is data entry, and it involves extensive use of the "format" and "entry" options from the main screen. Entry is mostly a pre-tournament operation, but you will also need it to take care of drops and adds after the tournament starts. For your own sanity, make sure that you back everything up every time you finish a major step in the data entry (teams, rooms, judges, etc.). Backup is done under the "format" option. Once all the data are entered, it is worth printing a tab copy of the team, judge, and room lists and posting them within eyesight of the computer. These are available under the "forms" option. Rich has made most tournament-time operations responsive to proper team names, but it is often useful to know the arbitrary computer number of a team or judge, and those numbers are available on the tab room copies of the lists of teams, rooms, and judges.

The second phase is preliminary-round tournament operation. This involves extensive use of the "operate" screen. Mostly, you will be entering ballots and pairing rounds. There are separate options for pairing preset and power-matched rounds. If you are the trusting sort and get confused when people start talking about z-scores and deviations, you can just hit the "pair round automatically" button and place faith blindly in Edwards, which usually works out for the best. The pairing function is well tested, and if the pairing appears a little screwy it is probably because the bracket is skewed; human intervention can produce a different, but usually not substantively better, result. If you would like to decide for yourself who gets pulled where there is plenty of latitude to do so, but if you want to leave the pairings as the computer spit them out you will often be okay, plus you can always say

“Hey, that’s the way it came out of the computer.” The automatic pairing function works better with larger divisions, but if you have a smaller division you will do well to eyeball the automatically generated pairings to see if there is an obvious skew that you might be able to fix.

If you are literate in bracket-speak and wish to have more direct control over the pairings, there is a “power match on screen” option that nicely combines computer-assistance with human control of the process. It takes a little getting used to, but with 15 minutes of practice it can be mastered. If you use this option, you will know why the pairings got skewed the way they did, and you can say things like “I know you got pulled up 3 brackets in your break round, but that’s because sides were constrained and you got pulled down twice.” Your final option for pairing rounds is the manual option, which is a pain and should only be used during emergencies – to match difficult to pair teams, or when things are so messed up the computer will not pair things any other way (this happens very rarely and usually only when the divisions are very small). If you power match manually, it is *very* helpful to have the tab printouts that list team, judge, and room numbers. The most common way to use the manual pair function is to print out team cards (available under the “contestants” option from the “forms” tab on the main menu), power match by hand using the cards, and then type the pairing into the computer using the manual pair option. You can still use the automatic functions to have the computer assign rooms and judges. These functions work well regardless of division size and whether or not the pairing function has been bothersome. Regardless of the matching routine you use, when you are done power matching and before you print out the pairings, make sure you click on the “check round” option under the “operate” tab. This can identify a number of problems that are not always obvious from the pairing screens, including teams and judges left off the pairings.

The third and final phase of operation is pairing elimination rounds. You do everything under the “elim” tab from the main menu, and it is totally different than everything you did during the prelims. The elim data is loaded when you print the results, and you will not have any data to work with until you send the print command. Pairings are produced under the “schedule elim judges” option. There is color coding to figure out and the options are a little complicated, so you definitely do not want to be trying to figure this out for the first time fifteen minutes before the elims are supposed to start. If you intend to run different elimination levels for different divisions at the same time, it is important that you set this up correctly in the format screens. Most of what you will be doing involves judge placement,

but do not forget to pay some attention to the room assignments. The computer will make them automatically, but there may be more shuffling around than necessary and if you do not plan in advance which rooms you will be using in later elims, you are sure to make a couple teams haul their tubs around more than they have to.

There are three things you should always do as a matter of course to avoid potential catastrophes. The first is to make floppy disk backups often. As a general rule, back up after each round has been paired and after each set of results has been entered. While you can save each backup on a separate floppy, overwriting backup files on a single disk usually is sufficient. Second, it is a good idea to post a tab copy of each round in the tab room, so you can go back and quickly check for potential conflicts (and to answer the most annoying questions that come into the tab room: "What room am I in?" "Where is my coach?" "Did I hit this team before?"). Third, you should have two people enter the results. Since the computer will do all the math correctly, the only chance of an error occurs if you enter the results incorrectly. A typical procedure is to have one person read the results and a second person enter them. Before the next ballot is entered, the original reader should watch the screen and the original enterer should read the ballot a second time. This double-check will catch 2-3 entry errors per tournament and save a bunch of headaches.

Cool Stuff TRPC Will and Won't Do. One pairing option TRPC has that is very useful for large tournaments spread over many buildings is the "presets in cells" option. It can make the presets go very smoothly and it comes up as an automatic option when you pair the presets but not for subsequent rounds. Basically, the function tries to guarantee that everyone gets an equal draw by placing the teams in "cells" and keeps all the teams in each cell within a 3-room distance of each other. The program also has a number of formats built in, including parliamentary tournaments, moot courts, and round robins. Advanced users who are proficient at website construction can set up a site that will save the entry to an access database that can be downloaded directly into TRPC, saving loads of data entry time. The format of the database is important, however, and if you want to try this option you are advised to consult with Edwards in advance.

A very recent addition is the ability to upload tournament entry data from text files, which allows you to enter judge, team, and school information as text files that can be imported directly into TRPC. The system was used at the 2000 Harvard tournament and was generally successful. The option is available under the "format" tab from the main menu and includes an instruction screen. Each year at the NDT Edwards makes available an

auxiliary program that allows teams to enter their judge preference sheets on a remote computer. Those files are then imported into TRPC. The unique format of the NDT makes this approach workable, but it is hard to imagine that it would work well in the context of a typical invitational tournament. However, the option is available, although it probably would require consultation with Edwards should you want to try it.

TRPC is, more or less, designed to process judge preference information in the A/B/C/Strike format, and does not support rankings with finer distinctions (e.g., a twelve category rating system or ranking all judges top to bottom). However, the most recent update does allow more levels of differentiation, with a default option using a six category rating system, with A+, A, B+, B, not ranked, and strike. Data is entered by typing a 1-6 on the keypad, and the computer converts the number into its alphabetic equivalent.

Where Things Might Get Dicey. So, you're done with the prelims, you are about to run your first power matched round, you told the computer to do it automatically, ran the "check round" option, and discovered that one team has been pulled up three brackets and two debates have no judges. What do you do now? The situation may sound dire, but these things happen all the time and are fairly easily corrected. To change the judges, go back up under "operate" and take the "display schedule" option. You can change the judges just by clicking on them. (Occasionally, not all pairings will appear; if so, try clicking on the "up twelve" button.) If the judge you want does not appear, this is probably because you made the judge ineligible for that division or unavailable for that round. You need to go back to the entry screen, enter the judge information correctly, and return to the "display schedule" screen to make the change. Very rarely, the judge will still not appear, and if that happens you can still make the change you want via the "enter pairings manually" option. If no judge has been assigned to a round, click on the blank space where the judge is supposed to be and a list of available judges will pop up.

To fix a bracket discrepancy, or if a team has not appeared on the pairings, you have three options. The best is probably the "power match on screen" option. You can usually see what the pairing problem is and changes are easy to make. Plan B is to try to re-pair the entire round using the automatic pairing functions. Obviously, it is best to try to change something slightly or else the computer will probably just produce the same pairing over again. This method has worked for me occasionally and it is worth a shot. If you take this route, make sure that you click the "erase any existing schedule" option, or you will just retain the mistakes. It is also quite important that you make sure you are working with the

correct round – if you want to pair round four, but you have round three on the screen and click the “erase any existing schedule” option, you are entering a level of hell even Dante could not imagine. You will have erased both the pairings and results from round 3 and will lose hours trying to re-create them. You will, however, have gained a deep appreciation for the value of backing up the data.

Your third choice is to pair the round manually. You can either switch just a couple of the match-ups or pair the entire round by hand. When you are done pairing by hand, you should still use the “check round” function, and you can still change judges and rooms easily from the “display round” option.

There are rare instances where things that should not happen do and things that should happen do not. Here are things to watch out for:

One of the very cool options is the “elim” selection that allows you to “select a pool of elim judges.” You can just point and click on everyone who will be around for a given elim round. This is much easier than prior systems. However, confusing things can happen when you are running multiple divisions and some judges are only available for a certain division. If retaining division information is important to you, it is probably best to bypass this option altogether and rely instead on the judge screens to include the information. Otherwise, make all judges available for all divisions and place them manually in the divisions they are most suited for.

When entering teams, it takes a little while to get the hang of when to hit the tab and when to hit the enter key, but even when you get used it there do seem to be occasions when you enter everything correctly and the entry still does not take. One good idea is to print out team and judge lists under the “forms” option when entry is done and then double check the lists off the original entries. This is good practice anyway, and will catch any computer glitch having to do with team entry.

If you have a small tournament, power-matching is usually difficult or impossible, and you have two pairing options to deal with the unique demands of a small tournament. One is the normal pairing you would use for a large tournament, and the other is a “preset all rounds in a small division” option. Strangely, there are times when the normal pairing works better in a small division than the “small division” option does. I have had a situation where the “auto preset in cells” option worked better in a small division than either of the other two options. The bottom line is that if you have a small division and the pairing option you are choosing is not working, it will not hurt to try another option.

There are times when you are entering ballots, especially when low point wins occur, when for some reason the computer will let you enter speaker points but not a decision. If you encounter this situation, you call the ballot up again and start from scratch.

There is one thing to watch out for that is not a computer bug but can produce strange results. The TRPC does support lag-based power matching. However, if you are power matching early in a tournament and you have selected “high/low” adjusted speaker points as your top tie-breaker you should make sure that you have had at least three rounds of competition entered. If you have the results for round one and wish to lag-power round three off round one during round two, the computer will actually have a negative number for adjusted points, having thrown out the sole result twice as both the high and the low. The perverse result is that the teams with the lowest point totals are actually the most highly ranked. Teams that receive byes should be watched carefully, because averaging based on only one round (or in some cases, no rounds) can result in skews that the computer will not fix unless you act to change the calculations.

If you find yourself trying to lag-power an early round and do wish to use high/low adjusted points as the first tie-breaker, you can decide to live with the results and usually nothing bad will happen. Alternatively, you can change the tie-breakers to make total points a more highly ranked tie-breaker than adjusted points. You can always change the tie-breakers back later. The danger in this option is that you might forget to change the tie-breakers back and advance the wrong teams.

Generally, it is worth tracking the way the computer averages speaker points for byes. If you notice something amiss, you can change the point totals in the “change” option from the main menu. If a bye does not seem to be taking, you can enter it from the manual pair screen. Pay special attention to the round for which you are assigning a bye.

The issue of specifying the correct number of rounds surfaces again when printing out the results sheets and you should make sure you specify the correct number of rounds that have been completed. Especially when you are running multiple divisions that offer a different number of preliminary rounds, the button you want is not necessarily the one that has been checked. Failure to specify rounds correctly will, at a minimum, result in the incorrect calculation of byes.

There are two general tendencies of the computer program that, when understood, can reduce the lingering feeling that something is going on inside the computer that you do not fully grasp. The first is that the program is generally designed for a large tournament that

follows typical intercollegiate pairing practices. Thus, the program will try to prevent teams from being heard by the same judge twice in preliminary rounds, will prevent a team from having an unequal number of affirmative and negative debates, and will prevent a team from debating another team from its own school. If you are running a small tournament, have a tournament with unusual judging procedures (for example, a small judging pool where judges hear a team more than once), teams flip for sides, or you encounter a coach who would prefer that teammates debate each other, your experience with the program will not be unlike trying to teach a cat to play like a dog – it will be possible, but not easy, and contrary to every instinct of the animal.

This leads to the second major theme. For virtually every problem that you are likely to encounter there are multiple ways to fix it. Often, the change you want to make but cannot simply needs to be made on a different screen. Occasionally, the change you wish to make should be possible from the screen you are looking at, but due to computer glitch, operator error, or weird planetary alignment some small malfunction prevents the change. When this happens, you can often make the same change in a number of different places in the program and you just have to keep trying the different options until one works. For instance, if you cannot enter the bye you want from the automatic pairing screen, you can try to make the same change on the “change cards” option, or via manual pairing, or via an on-screen power match. The more you use the program the more familiar you will become with the various options available, but if you get stuck and one solution does not seem to be working, try poking around and trying to find a different way to do the same thing. Most often, there is one.

The folly of writing a review of software originates in the slowness of the publication process mismatched to the speed of software development. The latest version of TRPC bears only a distant resemblance to the original TRM. Undoubtedly, by the time this review hits print parts of it will be irrelevant, old bugs will be found and killed, and new species of insects will arise to infect the circuitry of the TRPC. I will conclude by simply saying that, once the system is mastered, you are in a much better position to appreciate the improvements and recognize the insignificance of the remaining anomalies, and each evolutionary version is easily adopted.

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